

Absolutely — **subtle** is a strong polysemy target because your passage uses it here:

> “...not everyone would choose something so **subtle**.”

Here **subtle** means **delicate, understated, and not immediately obvious or attention-grabbing**. But the word also has important meanings involving **small differences, indirect influence, clever complexity, fine sensory qualities, and nuanced thinking**.

Word family: **subtle / subtly / subtlety**

Base word: subtle

Adverb: subtly

Noun: subtlety

Part of speech: adjective (形容詞)

Pronunciation note:

> **subtle** /'sʌtəl/

> the **b** is silent

Meaning in your passage: **subtle = delicate and understated — 含蓄的；低調細膩的；不張揚的**

Your sentence:

> “...not everyone would choose something so **subtle**.”

Here **subtle** means:

> **not strong, obvious, dramatic, or attention-seeking; instead, its effect is quiet, delicate, and refined.**

繁體中文：

效果不強烈、不張揚、一眼就抓住注意力，而是細膩、含蓄、低調地產生影響

Natural translation:

> “...not everyone would choose something so subtle.”

「並不是每個人都會選擇這種如此**含蓄細膩 / 低調柔和**的作品。」

So here:

> **subtle = 含蓄、細膩、不張揚的**

1. **subtle** = not obvious / difficult to notice — 細微的；不明顯的

A core meaning.

Practice 1

> “There is a **subtle** difference between the two colours.”

「這兩種顏色之間有一個**細微的差別**。」

Practice 2

> “She noticed a subtle change in his tone.”

「她注意到他的語氣有一點**細微的變化**。」

subtle = 差異、變化或特徵很小，不容易立刻察覺

2. **subtle** = delicate / understated in style — 含蓄的；低調細膩的

This is your exact source sense.

Practice 3 — Original

> “Not everyone would choose something so **subtle**.”

「不是每個人都會選擇這種如此**含蓄細膩**的作品。」

Practice 4

> “The painting uses subtle colours rather than bold contrasts.”

「這幅畫使用**細膩柔和的色彩**，而不是強烈對比。」

subtle = 風格、設計、藝術效果不誇張、不強烈，而是精細含蓄

3. **subtle** = indirect / not openly stated — 隱晦的；含蓄的

A major communication meaning.

Practice 5

> “The film contains a **subtle** criticism of modern society.”

「這部電影包含對現代社會的**隱晦批評**。」

Practice 6

> “She gave him a subtle hint.”

「她給了他一個**含蓄的暗示**。」

subtle = 意思沒有直接說明，而是透過暗示、語氣或細節表達

4. **subtle** = having fine distinctions / nuanced — 細膩的；有層次的

A major intellectual/artistic sense.

Practice 7

> “The novel makes a **subtle** distinction between ambition and greed.”

「這本小說對野心與貪婪作出了**細膩的區分**。」

Practice 8

> “Her interpretation is subtle and thoughtful.”

「她的詮釋很**細膩而有層次**。」

subtle = 能呈現細小差異、複雜層次或微妙關係

5. **subtle** = clever / sophisticated in a quiet way — 巧妙的；精妙的

A useful positive meaning.

Practice 9

> “The design uses a **subtle** visual trick.”

「這個設計運用了一個**巧妙的視覺手法**。」

Practice 10

> “It was a subtle strategy.”

「那是一個**精妙的策略**。」

****subtle = 方法或想法精巧、有技巧，但不是明顯直接的****

6. ****subtle = slight but real in sensory quality — 淡淡的；微妙的****

Common with smell, taste, colour, sound.

Practice 11

> “The tea has a ****subtle**** floral flavour.”

「這種茶有一種**淡淡的花香味**。」

Practice 12

> “There was a subtle scent of lemon in the room.”

「房間裡有一股**淡淡的檸檬香氣**。」

****subtle = 感官特徵不強烈，但確實可以察覺****

7. ****subtle = gradual / barely perceptible in effect — 微妙的；慢慢產生的****

Practice 13

> “The lighting creates a ****subtle**** shift in mood.”

「燈光營造出一種**微妙的氣氛轉變**。」

Practice 14

> “The change had a subtle effect on the room.”

「這個改變對房間產生了**細微但真實的影響**。」

****subtle = 效果不劇烈，但會逐漸或細緻地影響整體****

8. **subtle** = difficult to analyse or understand fully — 微妙複雜的；難以捉摸的

A more abstract sense.

Practice 15

> “The relationship between colour and mood is **subtle**.”

「色彩與情緒之間的關係很**微妙複雜**。」

Practice 16

> “It is a subtle problem with no simple answer.”

「這是一個**微妙而複雜**的問題，沒有簡單答案。」

subtle = 涉及複雜而細小的因素，不能用簡單方式理解

9. **subtly** = in a slight / understated way — 細微地；含蓄地

A major adverb use.

Practice 17

> “The colours change **subtly** across the canvas.”

「色彩在畫布上**細微地**變化。」

Practice 18

> “She subtly changed the subject.”

「她**不著痕跡地 / 含蓄地**轉換了話題。」

subtly = 以不明顯、細緻或間接的方式

10. **subtlety** = fine detail / delicate distinction — 細微之處；細膩差異

A major noun use.

Practice 19

> “You begin to notice the **subtleties** of the painting.”

「你開始注意到畫中的各種**細微之處 / 細膩層次**。」

Practice 20

> “The language contains many subtleties.”

「這種語言包含很多**細微差別**。」

subtlety = 不容易立刻察覺的細小差異、特徵或層次

11. **subtlety** = quality of being delicate/understated — 含蓄；細膩；精妙

Practice 21

> “I admire the **subtlety** of Monet’s use of colour.”

「我很欣賞 Monet 用色的**細膩 / 精妙**。」

Practice 22

> “The performance lacked subtlety.”

「這場表演缺乏**細膩感 / 含蓄度**。」

subtlety = 表達、設計或思考中細膩、含蓄、不粗糙的特質

Important distinction: **subtle** vs **gentle**

You just curated **gentle**.

gentle

= soft, calm, not forceful.

subtle

= not obvious, fine, understated.

> gentle colours

> = 柔和、不強烈的色彩

> subtle colours

> = 色差細膩、低調、不容易一下察覺的色彩

A painting can be both, but for different reasons.

Important distinction: **subtle vs slight**

slight

= small in amount/degree.

subtle

= small and not immediately obvious, often requiring attention to detect.

> slight change

> = 小變化

> subtle change

> = 細微而不易察覺的變化

Subtle adds the idea of delicacy or hiddenness.

Important distinction: **subtle vs vague**

subtle

= precise but not obvious.

vague

= unclear or insufficiently precise.

> subtle distinction

> = 很細微但真實的區分

> vague distinction

> = 區分不清楚

Almost opposite in precision.

Important distinction: **subtle vs hidden**

hidden

= deliberately or physically concealed.

subtle

= present but not obvious.

> hidden message

> = 被藏起來的訊息

> subtle message

> = 含蓄表達、需要理解才能察覺的訊息

Important distinction: **subtle vs indirect**

indirect

= not stated/done directly.

subtle

= indirect in a refined, fine, hard-to-notice way.

> indirect criticism

> = 間接批評

> subtle criticism

> = 含蓄且不易察覺的批評

Subtle is more nuanced.

Important distinction: **subtle vs delicate**

delicate

can mean:

- * fragile
- * fine
- * light
- * sensitive

subtle

emphasizes:

- * fine distinctions
- * understated effect
- * difficulty of noticing

> delicate flower

> = 脆弱 / 精緻的花

> subtle colour difference

> = 細微色差

Important distinction: **subtle vs sophisticated**

sophisticated

= advanced, refined, complex.

subtle

= finely nuanced and not obvious.

A sophisticated argument may be complex; a subtle argument may depend on fine distinctions.

Important distinction: **subtle vs obvious**

Direct contrast:

subtle

= not immediately noticeable

obvious

= easy to notice/understand

> subtle change

> = 細微變化

> obvious change

> = 明顯變化

Important distinction: **subtle vs dramatic**

Directly relevant to your Monet passage.

dramatic

= strong, striking, attention-grabbing.

subtle

= restrained, quiet, understated.

So:

> dramatic painting

> = 視覺 / 情緒效果強烈的畫

> subtle painting

> = 含蓄、細膩、不張揚的畫

This is one of the key contrasts in your passage.

Important distinction: **subtle flavour vs weak flavour**

subtle flavour

= light, delicate, nuanced flavour; often positive.

weak flavour

= not strong enough; often negative.

So:

> subtle ≠ weak

A subtle flavour may be intentional and refined.

Important distinction: **subtle hint vs clear instruction**

subtle hint

= 間接、含蓄地暗示

clear instruction

= 直接、明確地說明

If someone misses a subtle hint, that may simply be because it was designed not to be obvious.

Important distinction: **subtly vs slightly**

slightly

= by a small amount.

subtly

= in a fine, understated, not-obvious way.

> “The colour changed slightly.”

= 顏色變了一點。

> “The colour changed subtly.”

= 顏色以很細膩、不易察覺的方式變化。

Different nuance.

Important distinction: **subtlety vs detail**

****detail****

= any small part/information.

****subtlety****

= a fine distinction or delicate feature that may require careful attention.

> details of the painting

> = 畫中細節

> subtleties of the painting

> = 畫中那些細膩、微妙、不易察覺的層次

Pronunciation warning

****subtle****:

> /'sʌtəl/

The ****b** is silent******.

Same family:

> subtle

> subtly

> subtlety

The ****b** remains silent******.

This is worth flagging because the spelling strongly tempts learners to pronounce /b/.

Family-extension sweep

After the full audit, the useful modern family includes:

* ****subtle — not obvious**** = 細微 / 不明顯的

* ****subtle — artistic/style**** = 含蓄 / 低調細膩的

* ****subtle — indirect**** = 隱晦 / 含蓄的

* ****subtle — nuanced**** = 有細膩層次的

* ****subtle — clever/sophisticated**** = 巧妙 / 精妙的

* ****subtle — sensory**** = 淡淡 / 微妙的

* **subtle — effect** = 細微但真實的
 * **subtle — complex** = 微妙複雜、難以簡單理解的
 * **subtly** = 細微 / 含蓄 / 不著痕跡地
 * **subtlety — fine distinctions** = 細微差別 / 微妙之處
 * **subtlety — quality** = 細膩 / 含蓄 / 精妙

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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subtle — not obvious	差異、變化或特徵很小，不容易立即察覺
subtle — style/art	效果不誇張、不強烈，而是低調、細膩、含蓄的
subtle — indirect	意思不直接說明，而透過暗示、語氣或細節表達
subtle — nuanced	能呈現細小差異、複雜層次或微妙關係的
subtle — clever	方法或想法精巧、有技巧但不明顯直接的
subtle — sensory	味道、香氣、色彩等不強烈但可察覺的
subtle — effect	效果不劇烈，但會細緻或逐漸產生影響的
subtle — complex	涉及細小而複雜因素，難以用簡單方式理解的
subtly	以不明顯、細緻、間接或不著痕跡的方式
subtlety — distinction	不易立刻察覺的細小差異、特徵或層次
subtlety — quality	表達、設計或思考中細膩、含蓄、精妙的特質

For your original sentence

> “Of course, art is deeply personal, and not everyone would choose something so **subtle**.”

The exact meaning is:

**subtle = 這幅 Monet 畫作的美感不是靠強烈色彩、戲劇性場面或明顯衝擊，而是靠柔和色彩、細微光影和低調氣氛慢慢產生吸引力。 **

Natural translation:

> **「當然，藝術很個人化，不是每個人都會選擇這種如此含蓄細膩的作品。」 **

The highest-value contrasts are:

- > **subtle difference** → 細微差異
- > **subtle hint** → 含蓄暗示
- > **subtle criticism** → 隱晦批評
- > **subtle colours** → 細膩低調的色彩
- > **subtle flavour** → 淡淡而細膩的味道
- > **subtle strategy** → 巧妙策略
- > **subtly** → 細微地 / 不著痕跡地

> ****subtlety**** → 細微層次 / 精妙之處

> ****subtle vs gentle**** → 不明顯、含蓄細膩 vs 柔和、不強烈